defense minister when it was first mooted, said he “strenuously opposed” the purchase.

Then there was Arnaud Mimran, the 44-year-old French playboy accused of taking part in a vast carbon-trading fraud that may have cost European taxpayers €5 billion. French authorities called it the “heist of the century.” In May 2016, Mimran told a French court that he had given €1 million to Netanyahu’s reelection campaign. Apart from the ethical issues, the donation would have been a major violation of Israeli election law, which caps individual donations at about $3,000. Both men quickly changed their stories: Mimran later said the gift was actually €170,000, then just €40,000; Netanyahu initially denied receiving any money, then said it was for “public diplomacy on behalf of Israel”, not his campaign. The attorney general eventually opened an investigation.

The two were undeniably friends. Mimran told the court how he brought Netanyahu into a fancy private club in Paris; the French website Mediapart turned up photos of them dining in a seaside restaurant in Monte Carlo in 2003. That was a year after Mimran and six other defendants paid $1.3 million to settle insider-trading charges with the SEC. And he seemed to graduate quickly beyond securities fraud. Authorities believe that Mimran smuggled some of his stolen money through Israeli banks. The gangster who helped launder it turned up dead in 2010. Police have also accused Mimran of kidnapping another associate, a Swiss banker, and holding him hostage until he agreed to forfeit his share in a jointly-held company. He was a dubious associate for a head of government.

A veritable shadow cabinet has done time in Israeli prisons, which is one reason why Transparency International ranks Israel as among the most corrupt countries in the developed world. Aryeh Deri was convicted of taking bribes while serving as interior minister in the 1990s; he was reappointed to the same job in 2016, and quickly fell under investigation again. The previous prime minister, Ehud Olmert, is locked up for graft. In early 2016, on his last morning as a free man, a local radio station invited a former health minister—another ex-con—to offer some advice. (The guards are “not sentimental about ministers,” he noted.) Barak and Sharon were both investigated, though neither was charged.

At the center of many Netanyahu scandals is Sara—or “The Lady”, as the chattering classes sometimes call her. She lost two civil lawsuits in 2016 filed by former domestic workers who accused her of verbal and emotional